BASEBALL PLAYERS MEET AGAIN.—Frank White (right), second baseman for the Kansas City Royals, was one of six Kansas Citians to receive the William F. Yates Trustee Medallion for Distinguished Civic Service during opening convocation ceremonies Sept. 4, at William Jewell college. William Jewell senior Cory Wohlford, a former baseball star at Jewell, helped present White's medal. Wohlford, of Trimble, Mo., was partially paralyzed in an accident during the summer of 1985. The accident occurred two days before Wohlford was to have played in an all-star game with White's League Team. When he learned of the accident, White visited Wohlford in the hospital. He brought him an autographed bat and a baseball signed by the Royals.

Monday Nite Footballers

Commentary

By Jim Nunnelly

FRANK WHITE: Lucky, Exceptional and Wise With Words

In all the Sept. 13 heat, there was a festive atmosphere — a voter registration drive and amplified music. There was a Wayne Miner sponsored health care stand. There were countless balloons afloat and risky rides for the kids.

But, mostly there were speeches and words. Yes, words of praise, words of advice, words of history. A lot of words. It was Frank White Day in the city. The annual event was sponsored by the Key Coalition in Spring Valley Park.

Some of the words went like this. Charles Hazley recalled Frank White's younger athletic years. And Phil Curls introduced Vernon Thompson who praised Frank even further. The Reverend Keith Brown, in a Jesse Jackson style, emphasized the importance and histroy of neighborhood movements.

And Mayor Berkley continued by recognizing Frank White as a great person in addition to being a superstar. And, Jackie McGee, challenged the youngsters to "become seconds" and to follow in the "footsteps" of those "firsts" like Frank White. But what about Frank? And just what did he say? Let's listen in.

Dressed in a red, Izod-type leisure shirt and baggy white pants, Frank first humbly thanked the Key Coalition for honoring him. Afterwards, he became a little more serious and his words took on the tone of a benevolent leader in a time when the country is at "grave unrest."

He kept insisting and pointing out, "I'm an exception." He meant that it was unusual for "anyone" to "make it" to the Big Leagues. And being successful and earning money playing professional baseball! And having played for thirteen years, free of injury! Frank considers all of this just plain "lucky." Every word and gesture "drove home" the point, Frank White is just an exception to the rule. Most kids just don't make it that big.

He added that the average baseball player who makes it to the Major leagues only lasts an average of "4.5 years." That's pretty short, Frank.

Finally, the home grown, native son said something simple and profound. He urged the youngsters "to make education first." Put your books ahead of a baseball and a basketball. Depend on what's in your head, not what's in your hands. And though, he didn't say it over and over, this was really Frank's theme. It was his message for the day. And he chose "his" day to say it. Wow, what a guy. But, that's why he's Frank White.

Note: One of our Monday Niters, Ike Gardner, was Frank White's freshman general math teacher at Lincoln high school. He remembers Frank as a "good, solid student," averaging close to a B. He was a testimony to hard work, often practicing every day to achieve in his books and on the field. Never a discipline problem, Frank was "a solid citizen and very respectful" in every way. Ike added that "he's never forgotten from whence he came."

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